

AFRICA

With the world's largest desert, longest river, second-biggest tropical rain forest, and some of the world's biggest lakes, the large continent of Africa is a world-record holder. Sitting on either side of the Equator with a mainly hot climate, Africa contains a wealth of minerals, energy supplies, and other raw materials. African farming has adapted to the uncertainties of the weather from year to year, but at times farming can be difficult due to drought and the encroaching desert.

The Sahara

The world's largest desert, the Sahara stretches across almost the whole of North Africa. Thousands of years ago the Sahara had a moist climate, but today wet winds blowing in from the sea are blocked by dry winds sweeping out from the desert, keeping the land dry and parched.

The Maghreb

A word meaning "west" in Arabic, the term "Maghreb" was coined by the Egyptians to refer to the lands to their west, which include Tunisia, Algeria, and Morocco. The snow-capped peaks of Morocco's Atlas Mountains contrast with the hot desert in the south of the country.

The Nile

At 4,160 miles (6,695km) long with two main tributaries—the White Nile and the Blue Nile—the Nile is the world's longest river. It floods regularly, depositing vital fertile silt across its floodplain until, that is, the Aswan Dam was erected in southern Egypt, keeping back the river's much-needed silt at the expense of the farmland that lines its route in front of the dam.

